

Internet

This tab features your most favourite websites and also an address bar that launches the Web browser. Speaking of the Web browser, it is a modified version of the popular Gecko-based Mozilla Firefox. After the launch of Moblin v2.1, the browser has started to exhibit much better performance, along with support for plug-ins and add-ons.

However, there is a glitch here. I am a bit accustomed to the idea of typing away right after I press Ctrl+t to open a new tab. Here, the new tab shows `moblin://start/` on the address bar, with cursor after the slash. The implication of the same is, I need to physically select the text and then type, which I found to be pretty irritating. Interestingly, this was not the case in the Moblin we used on Mandriva (install the *task-moblin* package on Mandriva 2010 and you're done). There, `moblin://start/` was selected by default.

Media

The media player has a long way to go before it's ready for prime time. However, the underlying concept of accessing media content is quite brilliant.

An initial launching screen is presented, which allows the single-click launch of media content which is on the screen. This screen remembers your last search settings and presents things exactly as they were when you last closed the app. A search bar is presented allowing rapid access to the content you're looking for.

Accessing images automatically comes in a frame-by-frame viewing format, or they can be displayed in a continuous slide show. Videos are played from beginning to end after being selected, unless cancelled. However, if you let it finish then a bug in the current media player restarts playing content at the beginning of all media, rather than the next item in your search from where you launched the audio or video clip.

The media player interface hides all controls during viewing, and presents an automatic full screen experience. However, there are recurring bugs throughout, which prevent content from being shown when clicked, only heard, the pause doesn't always work properly, etc.

Pasteboard

Pasteboard is just another clipboard manager. However, something beautiful about this one is, it is persistent. That is, the contents of the pasteboard sustain across reboots.

Applications

The application tab houses a list of all the applications that are stored in your OS, along with links to Moblin's settings utilities.

Zones

This section helps you to manage, organise and switch between different applications. While I am still clueless about the usefulness of this 'feature', it just might be Moblin's attempt in emulating the concept of multiple desktops.

System tray

The system tray houses the Bluetooth settings (not available on previous versions), power options, screen brightness and connectivity information.

Finally...

At the outset, I am pretty pleased with Moblin. It is still very shaky as there are errors which pop up during normal use, at least once every hour. Even so, I can see the amazing and tremendous progress and potential in every aspect that I've seen so far.

The Moblin.org team has gone to great lengths to rethink the very concept of a user interface, even addressing future technologies like netbook touch-screens, and their effort shows in great regard. Moreover, the portability of netbook devices, their long battery life and their feature set make it a perfect target for a user-friendly Linux-based operating system.

My love and hate relationship with Moblin

1. No application is running, the MyZone screen should re-appear automatically, rather than forcing the user to press the Super key or moving the mouse to the top. After all, if a user is using his PC, what good is it to stare blindly at the desktop background image after closing an application?
2. The battery widget doesn't indicate the battery life in units of time. A mere percentage is hardly informative.
3. The nomenclature for the sound and brightness levels are uber cool.
4. The network manager (it's an application called ConnMan) is a major pain in you-know-where. While it has no issues using DHCP, there is absolutely no way to set up a static IP. Of course, you can always move to the console, but even there, we failed to associate the ESSID of the wireless network.
5. The new version of Moblin finally supports resolutions higher than the standard 1024x768.
6. There is no 'shut down', 'hibernate' or 'sleep' button on the UI. Only thing you can do is shut it off, by pressing your netbook's physical power button.
7. The only power save option available is to set the duration of inactivity before it goes to sleep.
8. Application menu's UI is innovative but not too handy. Thankfully, pressing Alt+F2 takes you to the application menu's search box.